Jews did not, however, make a successful economic adjustment to Palestinian conditions. In the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, a majority of Palestinian Jews apparently lived largely from accumulated savings or foreign charity. They were constantly sending messengers abroad to collect money from Jews in more prosperous countries. It was a common view that only a rich Jew should go to Palestine -- for he would find no occupation there but to study the Torah.

These pilgrims, travellers, and settlers -- religious and nationalist, for traditionally these two elements are not readily separable in Judaism -- served to freshen the memory of ancient Hebrew society in its own land. Jews have always known, in modern times, that Palestine was in fact inhabited primarily by non-Jewish people. But it was easy to regard these non-Jews as latecomers who had temporarily established themselves in a land pre-empted by earlier claimants. These strangers in the land must be treated considerately, according to the laws of justice and humanity, but the land in which they were living was the Land of Israel.

This view of the unique relationship between the Jewish people and the land of Palestine is by no means the exclusive property of Jews. On March 2, 1841 a Memorial petition was addressed to Lord Palmerston by 320 Protestants and Catholics. They wrote:

> Your Memorialists beg leave further to remind Your Lordship that the Land of Palestine was bestowed by the Sovereign of the Universe upon the descendants of Abraham as a permanent and inalienable possession nearly 4000 Years ago, and that neither conquests nor treaties among men can possibly effect their Title to it. He has also decreed that they shall again return to their Country and that the Gentiles shall be employed as the means of their restoration.